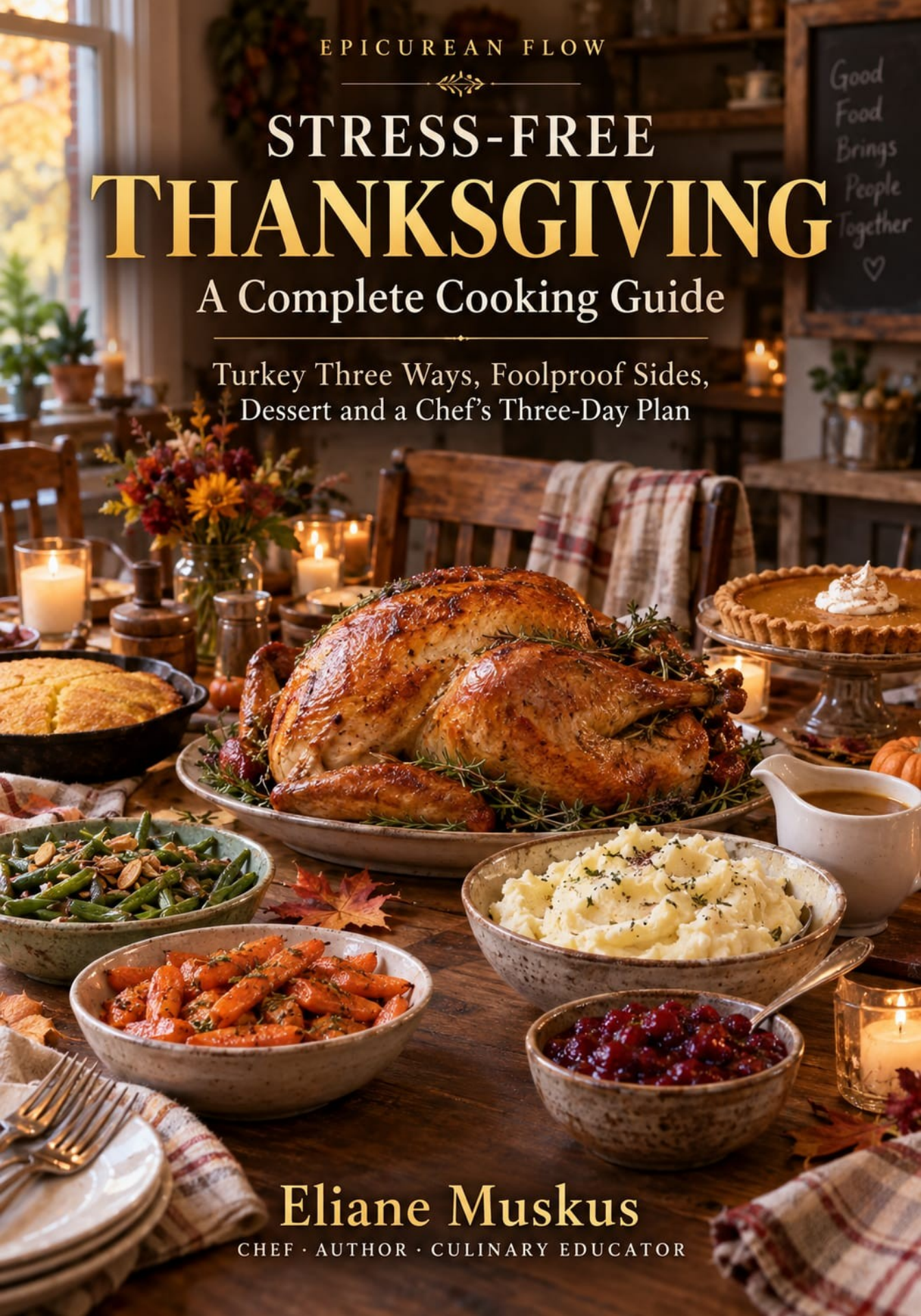




EPICUREAN FLOW

# STRESS-FREE THANKSGIVING

A Complete Cooking Guide

Turkey Three Ways, Foolproof Sides,  
Dessert and a Chef's Three-Day Plan

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**STRESS-FREE**

# Thanksgiving

A Complete Cooking Guide

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Written & created by  
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**EPICUREAN FLOW**

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## FOOD SAFETY AND ALLERGEN DISCLAIMER

The recipes in this guide are provided for general culinary information. Always follow safe food-handling practices, prevent cross-contamination and use a food thermometer where a safe internal temperature is specified. Cook turkey and other poultry to 74°C / 165°F at the thickest part. Ingredients and prepared products may contain or come into contact with allergens, including dairy, eggs, gluten, soy and tree nuts, and several recipes contain alcohol. Check every product label and adapt the menu to your guests' dietary requirements.

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# A calm, organized Thanksgiving

The goal is not to cook everything. It is to choose a clear plan and serve one coordinated meal with confidence.

Thanksgiving should be about laughter at the table and the aroma of good food filling the house—not a race against the clock. This guide brings the menu, equipment, shopping and timing into one practical system for six guests.

## WHAT'S INSIDE

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- Three turkey methods: low-temperature oven breast, slow-cooker legs or pressure-cooker legs.
- Three gravy options, five coordinated sides and classic pumpkin pie.
- Two complete bonus recipes: pumpkin gnocchi and rustic bread stuffing.
- A three-day planner, chef's success sheet, service secrets and safe leftovers guidance.

# How to Use This Guide

One decision first: choose the turkey method that fits your kitchen and schedule.

1

## **Choose one turkey method**

Roasted turkey breast, slow-cooker turkey legs or pressure-cooker turkey legs.

2

## **Confirm the menu for six**

The five sides and gravy are coordinated for six guests; the pie yields eight slices.

3

## **Read before shopping**

Review your selected recipes from beginning to end and check the equipment list.

4

## **Use the matching list**

Shop from the base menu, then add only the ingredients for your selected turkey option.

5

## **Work backward**

Choose your serving time and follow the three-day plan plus the correct turkey branch.

### **CHEF'S RULE**

Prep, cooking and resting times are guides. Use the specified equipment and confirm poultry doneness with a food thermometer at the thickest part.

# Equipment & Capacity Check

Confirm your appliance capacity before buying the turkey. Use only the equipment for your chosen method.

## ESSENTIAL FOR EVERY MENU

- ☐ Instant-read or probe food thermometer
- ☐ Large saucepan for potatoes and a medium saucepan for cranberry sauce
- ☐ Wide skillet for carrots, beans and gravy
- ☐ 23 cm / 9-inch pie dish and 23 cm / 9-inch cornbread pan or skillet
- ☐ Large mixing bowls, whisk, masher or ricer, colander and fine-mesh strainer
- ☐ Clean, sharp carving knife and stable carving board

## CHOOSE ONE TURKEY SETUP

### OVEN

Roasting pan with  
rack  
Heavy-duty foil  
Optional cheesecloth

### SLOW COOKER

6–7 L / 6–7 qt cooker  
Separate skillet for  
searing  
Heatproof tongs

### PRESSURE COOKER

8 L / 8 qt cooker  
Trivet if required by  
model  
Separate skillet  
optional

### OPTIONAL BUT USEFUL

Kitchen timer, warming tray, insulated gravy jug and oven-safe serving dishes.

# Master Shopping List for Six

Fresh produce and chilled ingredients for the five sides, one gravy and pumpkin pie.

## FRESH PRODUCE

- ☐ 1 kg / 2.2 lb carrots
- ☐ 1.5 kg / 3½ lb floury potatoes
- ☐ 800 g / 1¾ lb green beans
- ☐ 300 g / 10 oz fresh or frozen cranberries
- ☐ 2 onions, 1 bulb garlic and 4 celery stalks
- ☐ 1 orange, 2 lemons and 1 mild chilli or ½ red bell pepper
- ☐ Fresh thyme, rosemary, sage and flat-leaf parsley
- ☐ 150 g / 1½ cups corn kernels

## DAIRY, EGGS & CHILLED

- ☐ 350 g / 3 sticks unsalted butter, plus the amount listed for your turkey option
- ☐ 250 ml / 1 cup milk or cream for potatoes
- ☐ 240 ml / 1 cup buttermilk
- ☐ 240 ml / 1 cup evaporated milk
- ☐ 240 ml / 1 cup heavy cream and ½ tsp vanilla extract for whipped cream
- ☐ 4 large eggs
- ☐ 120 g / 1 cup shredded cheddar
- ☐ 1 unbaked 23 cm / 9-inch pie crust

### MENU LOGIC

Buy ingredients for one turkey method only. Choose one gravy: pan-dripping, herb gravy from cooker broth or make-ahead stock gravy.

# Pantry, Baking & Optional Bonus Items

Check your cupboards first. Quantities below cover the core menu; bonus-recipe items are listed separately.

## PANTRY & BAKING

- ☐ 425 g / 15 oz pumpkin purée for the pie
- ☐ All-purpose flour, fine cornmeal and baking powder
- ☐ Baking soda, granulated sugar and brown sugar
- ☐ Pure maple syrup and Dijon mustard (optional)
- ☐ Olive oil, fine sea salt and black or white pepper
- ☐ Cinnamon, nutmeg, ground ginger and cloves
- ☐ Sliced almonds, soy or tamari (optional) and bay leaves
- ☐ Dry white wine and Port (optional; stock can replace wine)

## BONUS RECIPES ONLY

- ☐ Additional 425 g / 15 oz pumpkin purée for gnocchi (850 g / 30 oz total if making both recipes)
- ☐ 250 g / 9 oz ricotta and 100 g / 1 cup Parmesan
- ☐ 1 additional egg yolk
- ☐ 450 g / 1 lb day-old rustic bread
- ☐ 2 additional large eggs
- ☐ Optional apple, pecans and dried cranberries
- ☐ Extra fresh sage and 600–750 ml / 2½–3 cups stock

### STOCK TOTALS - DO NOT DOUBLE COUNT

#### OVEN BREAST + PAN GRAVY

500–700 ml / 2–3 cups stock.

#### TURKEY LEGS + HERB GRAVY

750 ml / 3 cups total; the cooker broth becomes the gravy.

#### MAKE-AHEAD STOCK GRAVY

Add 1 L / 4 cups. With turkey legs, buy 1.75 L / 7 cups total.

#### BONUS STUFFING

Add 600–750 ml / 2½–3 cups.

### ALLERGEN CHECK

Core recipes may include dairy, eggs, gluten, soy, tree nuts and alcohol. Read packaged-food labels and prevent cross-contact according to your guests' needs.

# Turkey-Method Shopping Options

Choose one turkey column. Use the stock total for your turkey and gravy combination on the previous page.

**OVEN-ROASTED  
BREAST**

- ☐ 1 bone-in turkey breast, 1.8–2.2 kg / 4–5 lb
- ☐ 100 g / 7 tbsp butter
- ☐ 5 garlic cloves
- ☐ 1 lemon
- ☐ Extra thyme, rosemary and parsley
- ☐ Optional for pan-dripping gravy: 60 g butter, 120 ml / ½ cup wine and cheesecloth

**SLOW-COOKER LEGS**

- ☐ 4–6 fully thawed turkey legs, 2.5–3 kg / 5½–6½ lb
- ☐ 2 tbsp olive oil or butter
- ☐ 1 onion, 4 garlic cloves
- ☐ 2 carrots and 2 celery stalks
- ☐ 750 ml / 3 cups stock total
- ☐ Optional: replace 120 ml / ½ cup stock with dry white wine

**PRESSURE-COOKER  
LEGS**

- ☐ 4–6 fully thawed turkey legs, 2.5–3 kg / 5½–6½ lb
- ☐ 2 tbsp olive oil or butter
- ☐ 1 onion, 4 garlic cloves
- ☐ 2 carrots and 2 celery stalks
- ☐ 750 ml / 3 cups stock total
- ☐ Optional: replace 120 ml / ½ cup stock with dry white wine

**CAPACITY CHECK**

Use a 6–7 L / 6–7 qt slow cooker or an 8 L / 8 qt pressure cooker for the stated turkey-leg quantity. If your appliance is smaller, reduce the batch rather than overfill it.

# Turkey Three Ways

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Choose the method that suits your equipment and serving schedule. Each recipe serves six.

## RECIPE

# Low-Temperature Oven-Roasted Turkey Breast

Compound butter, gentle heat and a decisive thermometer reading create succulent slices.



### SERVES

6

### PREP

20 min

### COOK

1¼–1¾ hr

### OVEN

150°C / 300°F

## INGREDIENTS

- 1 bone-in, skin-on turkey breast (1.8–2.2 kg / 4–5 lb)
- 100 g / 7 tbsp unsalted butter, softened
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tbsp each thyme and rosemary, chopped
- 1 tbsp parsley, chopped
- Zest of 1 lemon
- 1¾ tsp fine sea salt
- ¾ tsp black pepper
- Optional baste: 60 g / 4 tbsp butter
- 120 ml / ½ cup dry white wine
- 2 garlic cloves, smashed
- 2 thyme sprigs and double cheesecloth

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

Make the compound butter up to two days ahead. If using the optional cheesecloth baste, reserve one-third of the mixture before soaking the cloth.

Allergens: Dairy; alcohol if wine is used.

# Low-Temperature Oven-Roasted Turkey Breast

Cook to 74°C / 165°F at the thickest part without touching bone, then rest 15–20 minutes.

---

## 01 Heat and dry

Heat the oven to 150°C / 300°F. Pat the fully thawed turkey breast thoroughly dry and set it on a rack in a roasting pan.

## 02 Make the compound butter

Mix the softened butter, minced garlic, chopped herbs, lemon zest, salt and pepper. Loosen the skin gently; spread half beneath it and the remainder over the surface.

## 03 Prepare the optional baste

Melt the butter with wine, smashed garlic and thyme. Reserve one-third in a clean bowl, then soak the cheesecloth in the remaining mixture and drape it over the breast.

## 04 Roast

Roast for 30 minutes with the cheesecloth in place. Remove the cloth carefully and baste every 15 minutes with the reserved mixture or pan juices.

## 05 Check doneness

Begin checking early. Insert the thermometer into the thickest part of the breast without touching bone. Remove from the oven when it reaches 74°C / 165°F.

## 06 Rest and carve

Tent loosely with foil and rest 15–20 minutes. Carve across the grain with a clean, sharp knife.

### CHEF'S NOTE

The thermometer—not the clock—is the final authority. Resting gives the juices time to settle and makes clean carving easier.

## RECIPE

# Slow-Cooker Turkey Legs with Herb Broth

A hands-off method with a deeply savoury broth ready to become gravy.



### SERVES

6

### PREP

20 min

### COOK

LOW 6–7 hr

### COOKER

6–7 L

## INGREDIENTS

- 4–6 fully thawed turkey legs (2.5–3 kg / 5½–6½ lb)
- 2 tbsp olive oil or butter
- 1 large onion, sliced
- 4 garlic cloves, smashed
- 2 carrots, chopped
- 2 celery stalks, chopped
- 750 ml / 3 cups low-sodium stock
- Optional: replace 120 ml / ½ cup stock with dry white wine
- 2 thyme sprigs
- 1 rosemary sprig
- 2 bay leaves
- 1½ tsp salt and ¾ tsp pepper, or to taste

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

The turkey must be fully thawed before slow cooking. Brown the legs in a separate hot pan for a deeper crust and richer gravy base.

Allergens: Dairy if butter is used; alcohol if wine is used.

# Slow-Cooker Turkey Legs with Herb Broth

Use a 6–7 L / 6–7 qt cooker and verify 74°C / 165°F at the thickest part.

## 01 Season and brown

Season the fully thawed legs with salt and pepper. Heat the oil or butter in a wide skillet and brown the legs well on all sides.

## 02 Build the base

Place onion, garlic, carrots and celery in the slow cooker. Nestle the browned legs on top and add the stock, optional wine and herbs.

## 03 Cook

Cover and cook on LOW for 6–7 hours or HIGH for 3–4 hours. Avoid lifting the lid during the first two hours.

## 04 Confirm doneness

Check the thickest part of each leg with a food thermometer. The turkey must reach 74°C / 165°F and should feel tender.

## 05 Rest and strain

Transfer the legs to a platter and rest 10–15 minutes. Strain the cooking liquid; skim excess fat and reserve it for the herb gravy.

## 06 Optional crisp finish

For crisper skin, place the cooked legs under a preheated broiler for 3–4 minutes, watching closely.

### FLAVOUR BALANCE

A covered slow cooker retains alcohol and liquid. The reduced wine quantity keeps the broth savoury; use stock instead for an alcohol-free menu.

## RECIPE

# Pressure-Cooker Turkey Legs

Holiday-ready turkey with a concentrated broth and a fast, predictable service window.



### SERVES

6

### PREP

20 min

### PRESSURE

35 min

### COOKER

8 L

## INGREDIENTS

- 4–6 fully thawed turkey legs (2.5–3 kg / 5½–6½ lb)
- 2 tbsp olive oil or butter
- 1 large onion, sliced
- 4 garlic cloves, smashed
- 2 carrots, chopped
- 2 celery stalks, chopped
- 750 ml / 3 cups low-sodium stock
- Optional: replace 120 ml / ½ cup stock with dry white wine
- 2 thyme sprigs
- 1 rosemary sprig
- 2 bay leaves
- 1½ tsp salt and ¾ tsp pepper, or to taste

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

Confirm that the turkey quantity does not exceed your cooker's maximum fill line. Consult the appliance manual if your model requires a different minimum liquid volume.

Allergens: Dairy if butter is used; alcohol if wine is used.

# Pressure-Cooker Turkey Legs

The stated timing is for an 8 L / 8 qt cooker; verify 74°C / 165°F at the thickest part.

---

## 01 Season and sear

Season the fully thawed legs. Brown them in batches using Sauté or a separate skillet, then set aside.

## 02 Sauté the aromatics

Cook the onion and garlic for 2–3 minutes. Add carrots and celery, scraping any browned bits from the base.

## 03 Load the cooker

Return the turkey legs and add stock, optional wine and herbs. Do not exceed the cooker's maximum fill line.

## 04 Pressure cook

Seal and cook on HIGH pressure for 35 minutes. Allow a 10-minute natural release, then release the remaining pressure according to the manufacturer's directions.

## 05 Confirm doneness

Check each leg at the thickest part. If any piece is below 74°C / 165°F, return it to pressure for the minimum additional time recommended for your model.

## 06 Rest, strain and finish

Rest the turkey 10–15 minutes. Strain and skim the liquid for gravy. Broil the legs for 3–4 minutes if a crisper surface is desired.

### APPLIANCE NOTE

Pressure-cooker performance varies by model and load. Always follow your manufacturer's operating instructions, respect the maximum fill line and confirm that every turkey leg has reached 74°C / 165°F at the thickest part.

# Three Gravies

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Match one gravy to your turkey method: pan drippings, cooker broth or a make-ahead stock base.

## RECIPE

# Pan-Dripping Gravy

For the oven-roasted turkey breast.



### YIELD

About 3 cups

### PREP

5 min

### COOK

10 min

## INGREDIENTS

- Pan juices from roasted turkey
- Optional: 60 ml / ¼ cup dry white wine
- 2 tbsp reserved turkey fat
- Salt and pepper
- 2 tbsp all-purpose flour
- Optional: 1 tsp Dijon or 2 tbsp cream
- 500–700 ml / 2–3 cups hot stock

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

If the gravy becomes too thick, loosen it with hot unsalted stock. If it is thin, simmer a little longer.

Allergens: Gluten; dairy if cream is used; alcohol if wine is used.

# Pan-Dripping Gravy

Read each step from start to finish before you begin, and prepare all measured ingredients first.

---

## 01 Separate

Pour the pan juices into a heatproof jug. Skim and reserve 2 tbsp fat.

## 02 Deglaze

Set the roasting pan over medium heat. Add wine or a splash of stock and scrape up the browned bits.

## 03 Make the roux

Add the reserved fat and flour. Whisk for 1–2 minutes.

## 04 Build

Whisk in the pan juices and enough hot stock to total about 700 ml / 3 cups. Simmer 5–8 minutes.

## 05 Finish

Season; add Dijon or cream if desired. Strain for an ultra-smooth gravy.

### CHEF'S NOTE

If the gravy becomes too thick, loosen it with hot unsalted stock. If it is thin, simmer a little longer.

## RECIPE

# Herb Gravy from Cooker Broth

For slow- or pressure-cooked turkey legs.



### YIELD

About 2 cups

### PREP

5 min

### COOK

12–15 min

## INGREDIENTS

- 750 ml / 3 cups strained cooker liquid
- 2 tbsp butter or skimmed turkey fat
- 2 tbsp all-purpose flour
- Salt and black pepper
- Optional: 1 tbsp chopped parsley or thyme

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

The cooker broth is concentrated. Taste first, then season. Add unsalted stock if it is stronger than you prefer.

Allergens: Gluten; dairy if butter is used.

# Herb Gravy from Cooker Broth

Read each step from start to finish before you begin, and prepare all measured ingredients first.

---

## 01 Reduce

Simmer the strained liquid until reduced by about one-third.

## 02 Cook the roux

In a separate saucepan, melt the butter or fat. Whisk in flour for 1–2 minutes.

## 03 Combine

Gradually whisk in the hot reduced liquid. Simmer 5–7 minutes until glossy.

## 04 Season

Taste before adding salt. Add pepper and fresh herbs; strain if desired.

### CHEF'S NOTE

The cooker broth is concentrated. Taste first, then season. Add unsalted stock if it is stronger than you prefer.

## RECIPE

# Make-Ahead Stock Gravy

No drippings needed; prepare up to two days ahead.



### YIELD

About 3½ cups

### PREP

10 min

### COOK

15 min

## INGREDIENTS

- 1 L / 4 cups prepared low-sodium stock
- 3 tbsp unsalted butter
- 3 tbsp all-purpose flour
- 1 small onion, finely chopped (optional)
- 1 tsp soy or tamari (optional)
- 1 tbsp chopped parsley
- Salt and pepper

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

Cool promptly and refrigerate. Reheat thoroughly over medium heat, whisking in a little unsalted stock if needed.

Allergens: Gluten and dairy; soy if soy sauce is used.

# Make-Ahead Stock Gravy

Read each step from start to finish before you begin, and prepare all measured ingredients first.

---

## 01 Soften

Melt butter and cook the onion gently for 4–5 minutes, if using.

## 02 Cook the flour

Whisk in the flour and cook for 2 minutes without browning.

## 03 Add stock

Gradually whisk in the hot prepared stock until smooth.

## 04 Simmer

Cook for 10–12 minutes, stirring, until the gravy coats a spoon.

## 05 Finish

Stir in soy, if using, and parsley. Season only after tasting.

### CHEF'S NOTE

Cool promptly and refrigerate. Reheat thoroughly over medium heat, whisking in a little unsalted stock if needed.

# Five Essential Sides

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A balanced table: one bright vegetable, one creamy classic, one crisp green, one tart sauce and one warm bake.

## RECIPE

# Maple-Glazed Carrots with Thyme

Bright, buttery and ready in minutes.



### SERVES

6

### PREP

10 min

### COOK

8–10 min

## INGREDIENTS

- 1 kg / 2.2 lb carrots, cut on the bias
- 2 tbsp unsalted butter
- 2 tbsp pure maple syrup
- 1 tsp thyme leaves
- Fine sea salt and black pepper
- Optional: toasted pecans

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

Blanch up to one day ahead, cool quickly and refrigerate. Glaze just before serving.

Allergens: Dairy; tree nuts if pecans are used.

# Maple-Glazed Carrots with Thyme

Read each step from start to finish before you begin, and prepare all measured ingredients first.

---

## 01 **Blanch**

Cook the carrots in simmering salted water for 4–5 minutes until just tender. Drain well.

## 02 **Build the glaze**

Melt butter in a wide skillet. Stir in maple syrup and thyme.

## 03 **Finish**

Add carrots and toss 3–4 minutes until glossy. Season and top with pecans if desired.

### **CHEF'S NOTE**

Blanch up to one day ahead, cool quickly and refrigerate. Glaze just before serving.

## RECIPE

# Creamy Mashed Potatoes

Silky, rich and easy to hold warm.



### SERVES

6

### PREP

15 min

### COOK

15–20 min

## INGREDIENTS

- 1.5 kg / 3½ lb floury potatoes, peeled and cubed
- 100 g / 7 tbsp unsalted butter
- 200–250 ml / ¾–1 cup warm milk or cream
- 1½ tsp salt, or to taste
- ½ tsp white pepper, or to taste

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

Hold in an oven-safe covered dish or over a gentle double boiler. Add a small splash of warm milk before serving if needed.

Allergens: Dairy.

# Creamy Mashed Potatoes

Read each step from start to finish before you begin, and prepare all measured ingredients first.

---

## 01 Boil

Cover potatoes with cold salted water. Bring to a boil and cook 12–15 minutes until tender.

## 02 Dry

Drain thoroughly, then return to the warm pan for 1–2 minutes to steam off moisture.

## 03 Mash

Pass through a ricer or mash by hand. Fold in butter, then add warm milk gradually.

## 04 Season

Taste and adjust salt and white pepper. Do not use a food processor.

### CHEF'S NOTE

Hold in an oven-safe covered dish or over a gentle double boiler. Add a small splash of warm milk before serving if needed.

## RECIPE

# Green Beans Amandine

Garlic, lemon and toasted almonds.



### SERVES

6

### PREP

10 min

### COOK

8 min

## INGREDIENTS

- 800 g / 1¾ lb green beans, trimmed
- 3 tbsp unsalted butter
- 3 garlic cloves, thinly sliced
- 60 g / ½ cup sliced almonds
- Zest of 1 lemon
- Salt and black pepper

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

Blanch the beans one day ahead. Dry them well before refrigerating so they reheat without becoming watery.

Allergens: Dairy and tree nuts.

# Green Beans Amandine

Read each step from start to finish before you begin, and prepare all measured ingredients first.

---

## 01 Blanch

Cook beans in boiling salted water for 3–4 minutes. Transfer to ice water, then drain well.

## 02 Toast

Melt butter in a wide skillet. Toast almonds for 1–2 minutes; add garlic for 30–60 seconds.

## 03 Finish

Add the beans and toss until hot. Season and finish with lemon zest.

### CHEF'S NOTE

Blanch the beans one day ahead. Dry them well before refrigerating so they reheat without becoming watery.

## RECIPE

# Cranberry Sauce with Orange Zest

Tart, jewel-bright and ideal for making ahead.



### YIELD

About 2 cups

### PREP

5 min

### COOK

12–15 min

## INGREDIENTS

- 300 g / 10 oz cranberries, fresh or frozen
- 150 g /  $\frac{3}{4}$  cup sugar
- 120 ml /  $\frac{1}{2}$  cup water or orange juice
- Zest of 1 orange
- Pinch of salt
- Optional: 2 tbsp Port

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

Make up to three days ahead. Bring to cool room temperature before serving if you prefer a softer texture.

Allergens: Alcohol if Port is used.

# Cranberry Sauce with Orange Zest

Read each step from start to finish before you begin, and prepare all measured ingredients first.

---

## 01 Combine

Place cranberries, sugar, liquid, orange zest, salt and Port, if using, in a saucepan.

## 02 Simmer

Bring to a gentle simmer and cook 12–15 minutes until the berries burst and the sauce thickens.

## 03 Cool

Transfer to a clean container. Cool, cover and refrigerate; the sauce thickens as it chills.

### CHEF'S NOTE

Make up to three days ahead. Bring to cool room temperature before serving if you prefer a softer texture.

## RECIPE

# Cheesy Cornbread with Peppers

A golden 23 cm / 9-inch skillet bake.



### MAKES

8 wedges

### PREP

15 min

### BAKE

25–30 min

### OVEN

190°C / 375°F

## INGREDIENTS

- 150 g / 1 cup fine cornmeal
- 120 g / 1 cup all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp baking powder
- ½ tsp baking soda and 1 tsp salt
- 240 ml / 1 cup buttermilk
- 115 g / ½ cup melted butter
- 120 g / 1 cup cheddar
- 150 g / 1½ cups corn kernels
- 1 mild chilli or ½ red bell pepper, diced
- 2 tbsp sugar
- 2 large eggs

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

Reheat wrapped in foil for a soft crumb. Uncover for the final few minutes if you want crisper edges.

Allergens: Gluten, dairy and eggs.

# Cheesy Cornbread with Peppers

Read each step from start to finish before you begin, and prepare all measured ingredients first.

---

## 01 Prepare

Heat the oven to 190°C / 375°F. Grease a 23 cm / 9-inch skillet or pan.

## 02 Mix

Whisk dry ingredients. In another bowl, whisk eggs, buttermilk and cooled melted butter.

## 03 Combine

Stir wet into dry just until combined. Fold in cheese, corn and pepper.

## 04 Bake

Bake 25–30 minutes until golden and a tester comes out clean. Rest 10 minutes.

### CHEF'S NOTE

Reheat wrapped in foil for a soft crumb. Uncover for the final few minutes if you want crisper edges.

# Dessert

---

Classic pumpkin pie is best baked the day before—one less task on Thanksgiving afternoon.

## RECIPE

# Classic Pumpkin Pie

Warm spices, a smooth filling and cinnamon-flecked whipped cream.



### MAKES

8 slices

### PREP

20 min

### BAKE

50–55 min

### OVEN

180°C / 350°F

## INGREDIENTS

- 1 unbaked 23 cm / 9-inch pie crust
- 425 g / 15 oz pumpkin purée
- 2 large eggs
- 240 ml / 1 cup evaporated milk
- 150 g / ¾ cup brown sugar
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- ½ tsp nutmeg
- ½ tsp ground ginger
- Pinch of cloves
- ¼ tsp salt
- 240 ml / 1 cup cold heavy cream
- 1½ tbsp sugar
- ½ tsp vanilla
- Pinch of cinnamon

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

Bake the pie one day ahead. Cool completely before covering and refrigerating. Add whipped cream only when serving.

Allergens: Gluten, dairy and eggs.

# Classic Pumpkin Pie

Bake at 180°C / 350°F until the outer filling is set and the centre still has a gentle wobble.

---

## 01 Heat the oven

Heat the oven to 180°C / 350°F. Place the unbaked crust in a 23 cm / 9-inch pie dish and chill while you mix the filling.

## 02 Mix the filling

Whisk pumpkin purée, eggs, evaporated milk, brown sugar, cinnamon, nutmeg, ginger, cloves and salt until completely smooth.

## 03 Fill

Set the pie dish on a rimmed tray. Pour the filling into the chilled crust and smooth the top.

## 04 Bake

Bake for 50–55 minutes. The edges should be set and the centre should wobble gently rather than ripple.

## 05 Cool and chill

Cool completely on a rack. Refrigerate within two hours, uncovered until cold and then lightly covered.

## 06 Whip and serve

Whip the cream with sugar, vanilla and cinnamon to soft peaks. Add to each slice immediately before serving.

### MAKE-AHEAD

A fully cooled pie slices more cleanly. Keep the whipped cream separate so the surface stays neat.

# Two Complete Bonus Recipes

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Use these as elegant alternatives, extra sides or a way to extend the holiday table.

## RECIPE

# Pumpkin Gnocchi with Sage Brown Butter

Tender pumpkin-ricotta dumplings finished with crisp sage and a subtle maple note.



### SERVES

6 as a side

### PREP

35 min

### COOK

15 min

## INGREDIENTS

- 425 g / 15 oz pumpkin purée, well drained
- 250 g / 9 oz ricotta, well drained
- 1 large egg yolk
- 60 g / ½ cup finely grated Parmesan
- ½ tsp fine sea salt
- Pinch of nutmeg
- 180–240 g / 1½–2 cups all-purpose flour, plus extra
- 115 g / ½ cup unsalted butter
- 12–15 fresh sage leaves
- Optional: 2 tbsp maple syrup
- Extra Parmesan and black pepper

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

Moisture varies. Drain both pumpkin and ricotta well; add only enough flour to make a soft dough that can be handled.

Allergens: Gluten, dairy and egg.

# Pumpkin Gnocchi with Sage Brown Butter

Work lightly and keep the dough soft. Too much flour makes the gnocchi heavy.

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## 01 Control the moisture

Spread pumpkin purée on a paper-towel-lined plate for 10 minutes. Drain ricotta in a fine sieve. Blot away excess liquid.

## 02 Mix the dough

Combine pumpkin, ricotta, egg yolk, Parmesan, salt and nutmeg. Fold in 180 g flour, then add more one tablespoon at a time only if the dough is too sticky to handle.

## 03 Shape

Divide into four pieces on a floured surface. Roll into ropes about 2 cm / ¾ inch thick and cut into 2.5 cm / 1-inch pieces.

## 04 Boil

Cook in batches in gently boiling salted water. When the gnocchi float, cook 1 minute more; lift out with a slotted spoon.

## 05 Brown the butter

Melt butter in a wide skillet until nutty and amber. Add sage and cook until crisp. Stir in maple syrup, if using.

## 06 Finish

Add the cooked gnocchi and toss gently. Pan-sear briefly for extra colour, then finish with Parmesan and black pepper.

## RECIPE

# Rustic Bread Stuffing with Caramelized Onions

Herb-scented, crisp-topped and baked in a generous casserole for the table.



### SERVES

8

### PREP

25 min

### BAKE

45 min

### OVEN

180°C / 350°F

## INGREDIENTS

- 450 g / 1 lb day-old rustic bread, cubed
- 60 g / 4 tbsp unsalted butter
- 2 large onions, thinly sliced
- 4 celery stalks, diced
- 3 garlic cloves, minced
- 1 tbsp chopped sage
- 2 tsp thyme leaves
- ½ cup chopped parsley
- 2 large eggs
- 600–750 ml / 2½–3 cups warm low-sodium stock
- 1 tsp salt and ½ tsp black pepper
- Optional: diced apple, pecans or dried cranberries

### CHEF'S NOTE & ALLERGENS

Use a buttered 23 × 33 cm / 9 × 13-inch baking dish. Add stock gradually so the bread is moist but not waterlogged.

Allergens: Gluten, dairy and eggs; tree nuts if pecans are used.

# Rustic Bread Stuffing with Caramelized Onions

Bake as a casserole to 74°C / 165°F at the centre. Cool and refrigerate promptly if making ahead.

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## 01 Dry the bread

Heat the oven to 150°C / 300°F. Spread bread cubes on a tray and dry for 15–20 minutes. Transfer to a large bowl and raise the oven to 180°C / 350°F.

## 02 Caramelize the onions

Melt butter in a wide skillet. Cook the onions over medium-low heat for 12–15 minutes until deeply softened and golden.

## 03 Add aromatics

Stir in celery and cook 5 minutes. Add garlic, sage and thyme for 1 minute. Season with salt and pepper.

## 04 Moisten

Add the vegetables and parsley to the bread. Whisk eggs with 600 ml stock and pour over. Toss gently; add more stock only as needed.

## 05 Bake covered

Transfer to a buttered 23 × 33 cm / 9 × 13-inch dish. Cover and bake 25 minutes.

## 06 Crisp and check

Uncover and bake 15–20 minutes more until golden and the centre reaches 74°C / 165°F.

# The Three-Day Plan

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Choose your serving time first, then work backward.  
Shared prep and turkey-specific start times are separated.

# T-3 Days to T-1 Day

Complete the calm, low-risk tasks early. Refrigerate prepared food promptly.

T-3 DAYS

- ☐ Finalize the menu and choose one turkey method.
- ☐ Check appliance capacity and serving dishes.
- ☐ Shop for pantry items and order the turkey.
- ☐ Make cranberry sauce; cool and refrigerate.

T-2 DAYS

- ☐ Shop for fresh and chilled ingredients.
- ☐ Make the stock gravy if using; cool and refrigerate.
- ☐ Make compound butter for the oven breast.
- ☐ Set out and label serving platters.

T-1 DAY

- ☐ Bake pumpkin pie; cool and refrigerate.
- ☐ Bake cornbread; cool and wrap.
- ☐ Blanch green beans and carrots; cool and refrigerate.
- ☐ Prep aromatics and herbs. Set the table.

IF MAKING BONUS RECIPES

If serving the bonus stuffing, assemble and bake it, cool promptly, cover and refrigerate. Reheat thoroughly on Thanksgiving Day until the centre reaches 74°C / 165°F.

# Thanksgiving Day — Shared Tasks

Example below assumes a 6:00 p.m. dinner. Shift every time equally if you plan to serve earlier or later.

|            |                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 9:00 a.m.  | Clear the kitchen, chill drinks, confirm the turkey is fully thawed and review your selected turkey branch.                                                                                               |
| 12:30 p.m. | Set the serving dishes in order. Keep the cranberry sauce refrigerated until approximately 30–60 minutes before serving if you prefer it less chilled.                                                    |
| 3:30 p.m.  | Follow the start time for your selected turkey method on the next page. If serving the make-ahead stuffing, begin reheating it according to your service schedule.                                        |
| 4:45 p.m.  | Cook potatoes. Reheat cornbread wrapped in foil; uncover briefly at the end for crisp edges.                                                                                                              |
| 5:15 p.m.  | Mash potatoes and hold safely. Glaze carrots and reheat green beans.                                                                                                                                      |
| 5:30 p.m.  | Finish the gravy and warm oven-safe plates over low heat. Keep the pie chilled and the cream refrigerated until dessert service.                                                                          |
| 5:40 p.m.  | Confirm that the turkey has completed its required resting time or is being held safely according to the selected turkey branch. Move the sides to warmed serving dishes and check hot-food temperatures. |
| 6:00 p.m.  | Carve, serve and enjoy the table.                                                                                                                                                                         |

# Turkey Start-Time Branches

Target: turkey rested and ready to carve at 5:40 p.m. for a 6:00 p.m. dinner.

## OVEN BREAST

Start prep: 3:30 p.m.

Into oven: about 3:50 p.m.

Begin checking: 5:05 p.m.

Rest: 15–20 min

Use Pan-Dripping Gravy.

## SLOW COOKER

Start prep: 9:30 a.m.

Cook on LOW: 10:00 a.m.

Begin checking: 4:30 p.m.

Rest: 10–15 min

Optional broil before service

Use Herb Gravy.

## PRESSURE COOKER

Start prep: 4:00 p.m.

Pressure on: about 4:25 p.m.

35 min HIGH + 10 min natural release

Check and rest: about 5:20 p.m.

Optional broil before service

Use Herb Gravy.

## TIME WISELY

These are planning estimates, not guarantees. Start checking before the predicted finish time and use the thermometer as the final doneness test. If the turkey finishes early, follow the hot-holding guidance in Chef's Secrets.

# Chef's Success Tip Sheet

Keep this page open on a tablet while you finish the meal.

## TURKEY

- Cook to 74°C / 165°F at the thickest part.
- Rest 15–20 minutes for the breast; 10–15 minutes for legs.
- Carve on a stable board with a clean, sharp knife.

## SIDES

- Blanch carrots and beans one day ahead.
- Use a ricer or hand masher—not a food processor—for potatoes.
- Add herbs, lemon zest and final seasoning just before serving.

## SERVICE

- Hold hot food at or above 60°C / 140°F.
- Use oven-safe dishes and cover food to protect it from drying out.
- Use labelled platters and separate timers for turkey, sides and gravy.

## GRAVY FIXES

- Too thin: simmer longer or add a 1:1 cornstarch slurry gradually.
- Too thick: whisk in hot unsalted stock.
- Too salty: dilute with unsalted stock; butter does not remove salt.

# Chef's Secrets

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Practical finishing details for calm carving, reliable reheating and a polished table.

# Carving & Safe Hot Holding

The final twenty minutes are about temperature control, clean carving and a calm sequence.

## CARVE WITH CONFIDENCE

- Rest the turkey for the same time stated in its recipe: 15–20 minutes for breast, 10–15 minutes for legs.
- Use a clean, sharp carving knife and a stable carving board with a juice groove.
- Remove the breast from the bone before slicing across the grain. Separate legs at the joint and slice only if desired.
- Arrange slices on a warm platter and spoon over only enough hot broth to keep the surface moist.

### IF THE TURKEY IS READY EARLY

Keep carved or whole cooked turkey at or above 60°C / 140°F in a covered, oven-safe dish. If you cannot maintain that temperature, refrigerate promptly in shallow containers and reheat safely before serving.

### PROTECT THE MEAT

A low holding oven can dry turkey. Keep the dish covered, add a small amount of unsalted hot broth and check the food temperature—not just the oven setting.

# Reheating Sides & Warming the Table

Reheating means bringing chilled food back to a safe serving temperature; holding means keeping already-hot food hot.

## MASHED POTATOES

Reheat thoroughly in a covered oven-safe dish or saucepan, stirring in warm milk as needed. Once hot, hold covered and prevent the edges from drying.

## STUFFING

Reheat covered until the centre reaches 74°C / 165°F. Uncover briefly at the end to restore a crisp top.

## CORNBREAD

Wrap in foil and reheat until warmed through. For crisper edges, open the foil or uncover the cornbread during the final few minutes.

## WARM PLATES

Use oven-safe plates only. Warm them at a low temperature for about 5 minutes, handle with dry towels and warn guests that plates are warm.

## HOLDING OVEN

If using an 80–100°C / 175–210°F oven for short-term holding, verify that food remains at or above 60°C / 140°F. Cover dishes and add moisture where appropriate.

# Wine, Alcohol-Free Pairings & Atmosphere

Keep the choices versatile and the kitchen fragrance subtle enough to let the meal lead.

## PAIRING GUIDE

### WHITE

Chardonnay with moderate oak or an aromatic Viognier complements turkey, butter and sweet vegetables.

### RED

If you want to serve one red, Pinot Noir is a versatile choice across turkey, herbs, cranberry and gravy.

### ALCOHOL-FREE

Sparkling apple cider, chilled cranberry-orange spritz or rosemary-lemon sparkling water.

## KITCHEN FRAGRANCE

Simmer orange peel, cinnamon and rosemary in a small pan of water on the lowest heat. Keep it attended and check the water level regularly. Turn it off before the meal so the food aromas remain central.

# Last-Minute Quick Fixes

Small corrections are part of cooking. Adjust gradually, taste again and keep the menu moving.

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## GRAVY TOO THIN

Mix 1 tbsp cornstarch with 1 tbsp cold water. Whisk in a little at a time and simmer briefly before adding more.

## GRAVY TOO THICK

Whisk in hot unsalted stock until it flows smoothly from a spoon.

## GRAVY TOO SALTY

Dilute with unsalted stock. If necessary, make a small unsalted roux-and-stock base and blend it in. Butter does not remove salt.

## SIDES COOLING

Move only oven-safe dishes to a low holding oven. Keep food covered and check that hot food remains at or above 60°C / 140°F.

## TURKEY FINISHED EARLY

Hold safely above 60°C / 140°F for a short period or refrigerate promptly and reheat. Do not leave it at room temperature while the sides finish.

## THE KITCHEN FEELS BUSY

Stop for sixty seconds. Clear the sink, check the turkey temperature, identify the next two tasks and ignore anything that is purely decorative.

# Leftovers & Safe Reheating

Cool food quickly, store it in shallow containers and reheat only what you plan to serve.

1

## Refrigerate promptly

Refrigerate cooked food within two hours of cooking or removing it from hot holding. Divide large amounts into shallow containers so they cool quickly.

2

## Separate for quality

Store sliced turkey, gravy, potatoes, vegetables and stuffing separately. Label containers with the date.

3

## Reheat safely

Reheat leftovers thoroughly to 74°C / 165°F. Bring gravy to a rolling boil while stirring. Add a splash of stock to turkey before covering and reheating.

4

## Use leftovers well

Fold turkey into soup or a warm grain bowl, turn mashed potatoes into crisp cakes, spoon cranberry sauce into yoghurt or sandwiches and cube cornbread for croutons.

### FOOD-SAFETY STANDARD

If food has been left at room temperature beyond the safe window, do not rely on smell or appearance. When in doubt, discard it.

THANK YOU

# From my kitchen to yours

Thank you for inviting me into your Thanksgiving kitchen. My hope is that this guide helps you plan with confidence, cook without unnecessary pressure and still have time to enjoy the people around your table.

Choose the turkey method that suits your kitchen, prepare what you can in advance and remember that a memorable meal does not depend on doing everything at the last minute.

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EPICUREAN FLOW

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She later created Born to Taste in Amsterdam and now develops cookbooks, courses and chef-led culinary content through Epicurean Flow from Málaga, Southern Spain. Her work combines professional technique with generous hospitality and practical guidance for the home cook.

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EPICUREAN FLOW

Cook with confidence.  
Gather with ease.

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